Cubs

By Patrick F. McManus

PATRICK: **(Pg 61-74)** I like to think I was just as good a Cub Scout as the next guy, the next guy being Grover Finch, who was about as miserable a Cub Scout as ever tied a granny knot and called it square. Our den could boast of boys clearly cut out for the scouting life, but I wasn't one of them. Neither was Grover. He dropped out of Cubs shortly after the strange incident at Camp Muskrat. I think he may have received a dishonorable discharge, but I don't know for sure.

INTRODUCTION

Scouting has come a long way over the years. Today, the Boy Scouts has made strides to become more inclusive. Cub Scouts is, and I quote, "a program for children (both boys and girls) in kindergarten through fifth grade and their families that encourages learning, friendship—and most of all—getting out and having fun!"

But when Patrick McManus was a cub scout, it was boys ONLY and they used the word FUN too! Those were the days when FUN may have been more loosely defined. But seriously: a 5-mile hike with a backpack that weighed more than you and skinny-dipping in a frozen lake does not fit the FUN definition!

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PATRICK: One day in early spring, the scoutmaster of the local troop showed up at our [cub scout] meeting. Mr. Tiddle was a robust outdoorsman, shaped something like a barrel, but all bone and muscle. He lifted weights and did calisthenics just for the fun of it, but the strangest thing was that every New Year's Day he would chop a big hole in the ice and plunge into the frigid water of Lake Blight.

MR. TIDDLE: *(booming)* Boys, I've got great news for you. A couple of the scouts from Troop Nine-oh-seven and I are going to take you Cubs on an overnight outing to Camp Muskrat this Saturday. How does that sound?"

PATRICK: We broke into cheers, with Grover cheering the loudest of all.

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MR. TIDDLE: You all show up at the school at eight o'clock Saturday, and we'll issue you sleeping bags and packs. For supper, we'll treat you to a wiener roast.

SCOUTS: Yayyyyyyyy!

PATRICK: The next Saturday morning, about fifteen of us Cubs assembled at the grade school. Several station wagons were parked nearby. We assumed they were there to transport us to Camp Muskrat, located on a small lake five miles from town. Then we noticed that volunteered fathers were loading the station wagons with tents and other gear and supplies. We watched as the station wagons departed one by one, until none were left for us. Mr. Tiddle and two Boy Scouts, all three in their starched tan uniforms, strode briskly over to us.

MR. TIDDLE: *(bellowing enthusiastically)* Listen up, Cubs! We have a real treat for you. Scouts Lucifer and Attila have volunteered to serve as your leaders on the campout, and they have come up with a marvelous idea. Instead of riding to Camp Muskrat, you get to practice your hiking skills all the way out to the camp. Let's have a big hand for these fine scouts.

PATRICK: *(less than enthusiastic clapping)* We stared up at the towering scouts, both of whom smiled benevolently down on us.

MR. TIDDLE: I leave you in their care. See you all at Camp Muskrat.

PATRICK: He got into his car and drove away. The two scouts watched his car until it disappeared around a corner. When they turned back to us, we were shocked. They had gown fangs and claws and their eyes glowed red with fiery light! We could tell from their gleefully evil expressions this was an opportunity they had waited for all their lives.

ATTILA: *(mean and threatening)* Hoist your packs and line up according to height, shrimps! No talking! Move it! Move it!

PATRICK: Startled, we hoisted our packs and scrambled into a ragged line.

PORKY: Hey, I just remembered. I'm supposed to go to the dentist today! See you guys later.

DANNY: I have to go to the bathroom. Be right back.

TONY: Me too. Be gone just a second.

LUCIFER: *(snarling)* Shut up, shrimps! Back in formation!

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PATRICK: The would-be deserters shrank back into line.

LUCIFER: *(screaming)* Left face!

ATTILA: *(bellowing)* Forwarrrrrd! March! Hut two three four, hut . . .

PATRICK: Attila brought up the rear, apparently for the purpose of harrying the stragglers and shooting the wounded.

PEEWEE: *(croaking)* How much farther is it?

LUCIFER: *(shouting)* Four miles to go! Now close up that line! Hut two three four . . .

PATRICK: The hot spots of blisters began to glow inside our tennis shoes. Pack straps gnawed at our shoulders.

GROVER: *(muttering)* This ain't a hike. It's a death march

PATRICK: *(to Grover)* Somebody is going to pay for this. *(to audience)* Hours later we limped into Camp Muskrat and dropped to the frozen, snow-blotched ground. The fathers had set up the tents and then vanished with the blinding speed common to fathers volunteered for Cub Scout outings. Mr. Tiddle and the two scouts were now left alone with fifteen exhausted but surly Cubs, who sprawled in ominous silence, sullenly watching Attila, Lucifer, and Mr. Tiddle job about gathering wood for the evening campfire. The scouts and scoutmaster joked and laughed as if they hadn't a care in the world. The air, however, was heavy with suspense, dark with foreboding. I crawled over to the remains of Grover and Peewee. *(to Grover)* Come up with anything for Lucifer and Attila yet?

GROVER: I'm thinking, I'm thinking. Everything I come up with is either too kind or too complicated. We need something simple but mean. I suppose we could steal their clothes so they would have to run around naked in the cold and maybe catch pneumonia and suffer horribly for a long time and then die terrible agonizing deaths.

PATRICK: The sun sank behind Muskrat Mountain, and a breeze wafted in off Muskrat Lake, chilled by rafts of sludgy ice still drifting about the surface. We put on sweaters and even coats and gathered around the fire that Lucifer and Attila had built into a small inferno. This was more like it.

PEEWEE: Are we camping yet?

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PATRICK: Suddenly, Mr. Tiddle erupted from his tent with a towel thrown over his shoulder.

MR. TIDDLE: Any of you Cubs like to join me for a dip in the lake? What, no takers? *(to Lucifer and Attila)* How about you scouts? Like to refresh yourselves with a dip before supper? There's a nice sandy beach down the shore a ways, and we don't even have to chop through the ice. Just shove it out of the way."

ATTILA: *(shuddering)* Why, we'd sure like to Mr. Tiddle. Sounds wonderful. But darn it all, we didn't bring our bathing trunks.

MR. TIDDLE: *(bellowing)* Me neither. Ever hear of skinny-dipping? C'mon, lads. Race you out to the floating dock!

LUCIFER: *(whining)* Wow, okay then, Mr. Tiddle. Attila and I'll be right there, as soon as we grab some towels. Hope we can find you in the dark.

PATRICK: The two scouts slouched off. We Cubs edged closer to the toasty campfire.

GROVER: This is too good to be true. Be back in a bit.

PATRICK: And [he] slipped off into the shadows. Scarcely had Grover vanished when the plot thickened. The headlights of a car illuminated the Camp Muskrat parking area for a moment, and soon Mrs. Slocum *(our den mother)* and another lady came picking their way down a trail to the campfire.

MRS. SLOCUM: Good evening, Cubs! You look like you're having a wonderful time. I'm so glad! I think you all know my good friend Mrs. Teasdale. We thought we would join you for the wiener roast. Brought you a treat – marshmallows!

SCOUTS: Yayyyyyyy!

PATRICK: We pulled up a log for the ladies to sit on next to the fire Just then Grover emerged from the woods, slapping his way through a cloud of mosquitoes.

GROVER: *(whispering to Patrick)* Snatched only one set of clothes and a towel. Was all I could find in the dark. I could hear them splashing around not too far from shore and thought they might spot me. Slipped the clothes into their tent. But either Lucifer or Attila is going to be in for a big surprise!

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PATRICK: We sat around the fire telling ghost stories, but nothing compared to the horror that awaited us. Sooner than expected, Lucifer came rushing into the light of the fire.

LUCIFER: Wow, you guys are smarter than you look. That water is liquid ice. Just lucky I had the good sense to test it with my toe first– why, hello there, Mrs. Slocum, Mrs. Teasdale. Didn't know you were coming for a visit.

GROVER: *(whispering to Patrick and snickering)* Attila's the one. This could be good.

PATRICK: A minute later, Attila bounded into camp – fully clothed!

ATTILA: Wheweeee, that water's cold! Chickening out is the better part of valor, I always say. I don't know how Mr. Tiddle can stand it.

PATRICK: Grover stared grimly at Lucifer and Attila. Minutes dragged by. We sang a camp song. Mrs. Slocum and Mrs. Teasdale told about when they were little girls and had picked huckleberries in the hills above Camp Muskrat. And then . . . The monster roared out of the darkness so suddenly that several Cubs almost inhaled flaming marshmallows. For a moment I thought it was a Sasquatch, but it turned out to be Mr. Tiddle. He was stark naked, except for a little cedar bough he had twisted off a tree.

MR. TIDDLE: *(booming)* So, the old steal-the-clothes trick!

GROVER: *(whispering to Patrick)* I thought this might happen. You can have my bike and baseball glove if you want them.

PATRICK: *(to Grover)* Thanks, Grover. Hey, it's been fun knowing you. *(to audience)* Then a surprising thing happened. Mr. Tiddle grabbed Lucifer and Attila by the hair, one with each hand.

MR. TIDDLE: Ha! Just as I suspected – hair's not even wet! Well, I'll just have to see what I can do about that.

ATTILA: Wait! **LUCIFER:** It wasn't . . !

MR. TIDDLE: Oh, it wasn't, was it? Well, we'll just check your tent and see if we don't find my clothes there.

PATRICK: Mr. Tiddle dragged the two scouts over to check their tent.

LUCIFER: See, your clothes aren't . . . . NOOOOOOOO!

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MR. TIDDLE: Aha! You two scalawags thought you could pull a fast one on me, did you?

PATRICK: He snatched up each of the scouts by the back of the belt and charged off toward the lake, one in each meaty hand. The screams were among the best and most satisfying I've ever heard, starting low and quavering but then rising in pitch and volume while still conveying great feeling and intensity right up to the moment of total immersion. We Cubs all agreed the performance was highly entertaining, spiritually enriching, and well worth a forced march. Recovering his little cedar branch, Mr. Tiddle strolled back to the fire chortling.

MR. TIDDLE: Please excuse my nudity for a minute, boys. I just wanted to make a point about practical jokes – oh, nice to see you, Mrs. Slocum, Mrs. Teasdale. Didn't expect you ladies out this evening. The point I was making to the Cubs here is that people can play their little pranks, but in the end they have to pay the pipe – Ladies?

PATRICK: His lips froze in a grotesque smile over his big white teeth. He hunched over and tried to conceal himself behind the little bough. I sure would have felt embarrassed if I'd been standing there naked except for a little cedar bough and suddenly realized two ladies were sitting not ten feet away.

PEEWEE: Yeah. Then, as if that wasn't bad enough, dumb ol' Terry accidentally flicks his flaming marshmallow onto the cedar bough. That ol' bough must have been dry as gunpowder, to flare up like that. Poor Mr. Tiddle,

PATRICK: I think both Mrs. Slocum and Mrs. Teasdale handled it pretty well. It was nice how they pretended not to notice Mr. Tiddle because of concentrating so hard on twirling their sticks over the coals, just as if roasting wieners was the most important thing in the world to them.

PEEWEE: It would have been better if they hadn't let their wieners burn off and fall in the fire, though. They didn't even seem to notice. Just sat there twirling them empty sticks round and round, an all the while Mr. Tiddle's roaring and darting about like a madman.

PATRICK: Well, I guess that's camping!

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